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Guide to intercultural education and social inclusion for youth workers

Cultural Bridges: strengthening interculturality and social inclusion among youth

Erasmus+ Programme — KA210-YOU Small-Scale Partnerships in Youth
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Foreword

Dear Youth Workers, Educators, and Community Leaders,

We are pleased to present this *Guide to Intercultural Education and Social Inclusion for Youth Workers*, developed within the framework of the Erasmus+ project **Cultural Bridges: Strengthening Interculturality and Social Inclusion among Youth** (KA210-YOU-F84AFCB3).

This guide is the result of eighteen months of collaborative work between three youth organisations from Spain, Poland, and France — countries with distinct cultural landscapes yet united by common European values and a shared commitment to building inclusive societies. It draws on the direct experience of our partnership, including the international youth exchange held in Warsaw in May 2025, as well as decades of collective expertise in non-formal education.

Our aim is to provide a practical, accessible, and reusable resource for anyone working with young people in intercultural settings. Whether you are a youth worker in a local association, a teacher seeking to bring intercultural education into your classroom, or a community organiser looking for participatory methods to foster inclusion, this guide offers you conceptual foundations, ready-to-use workshop activities, and practical advice grounded in real experience.

The need for such a resource has never been greater. Across Europe, young people encounter cultural diversity on a daily basis — in their neighbourhoods, schools, workplaces, and online spaces. Yet the skills needed to navigate this diversity with openness, empathy, and critical thinking are rarely taught in formal education. This guide seeks to fill that gap by equipping youth workers with the tools and knowledge to facilitate meaningful intercultural learning.

We hope this guide will inspire you to take action in your own community, to create spaces where young people can meet, learn from one another, and build bridges across cultural differences.

In solidarity and partnership,

The Cultural Bridges Partnership

Associacio Juvenil Ndiatiguia Joves Units, UGPA POLSKA, and Un Geste pour l'Avenir

About the project

Project overview

Cultural Bridges: Strengthening Interculturality and Social Inclusion among Youth (CCIY) is a Small-Scale Partnership funded under the Erasmus+ programme, Key Action 2 (KA210-YOU — Partnerships for Cooperation in Youth).

- **Project Duration:** 01 December 2024 – 31 May 2026
- **Total Budget:** 60,000 EUR
- **FormID:** KA210-YOU-F84AFCB3

Objectives

The project pursues the following objectives:

1. **Promote intercultural dialogue and mutual understanding** among young people from diverse cultural backgrounds across Europe.
2. **Combat racism, discrimination, and social exclusion** by raising awareness and building competences among youth and youth workers.
3. **Develop and share non-formal education methods** that can be replicated by schools, youth associations, and community organisations.
4. **Strengthen the capacity of partner organisations** to work with diverse and disadvantaged youth populations.
5. **Create lasting educational resources** — including this guide — that can serve as tools for intercultural education beyond the project's lifetime.

The partnership

The project brings together three complementary youth organisations:

Associacio Juvenil Ndiatiguia Joves Units (Barcelona, Spain) — *Coordinating Organisation*

A youth association founded by young people of African descent in Catalonia, working at the intersection of migration, cultural identity, and youth empowerment. The association organises intercultural events, mentoring programmes, and advocacy campaigns promoting the social inclusion of young people with migrant backgrounds.

UGPA POLSKA (Warsaw, Poland)

A Polish youth organisation with expertise in non-formal education, European mobility, and community development. UGPA POLSKA has extensive experience in organising international youth exchanges and training courses, with a particular focus on active citizenship and social participation.

Un Geste pour l'Avenir (France)

A French association dedicated to youth education, social inclusion, and sustainable development. The organisation works with young people from urban and rural areas, using creative and participatory methods to promote civic engagement and intercultural awareness.

Key activities

The project includes the following main activities:

- **Transnational partner meetings** for coordination and capacity building
- **International youth exchange in Warsaw** (14–18 May 2025) — a five-day programme bringing together 30 participants aged 18–30 from Spain, Poland, and France
- **Development of educational resources**, including this guide
- **Local dissemination activities** in each partner country
- **Evaluation and impact assessment** throughout the project lifecycle

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Chapter 1: Understanding interculturality

1.1 Introduction

Culture is not a fixed or monolithic entity. It is a dynamic, evolving process shaped by history, geography, language, religion, social structures, and individual experience. Every person carries multiple cultural identities — shaped by their nationality, ethnicity, gender, age, profession, interests, and life experiences. Understanding this complexity is the foundation of intercultural education.

This chapter introduces the key concepts that underpin the work of the Cultural Bridges project and provides a framework for understanding interculturality in the context of youth work.

1.2 Key concepts and definitions

Culture

Culture encompasses the shared beliefs, values, customs, behaviours, and artefacts that members of a society use to cope with their world and with one another. It includes both visible elements (food, clothing, language, art, rituals) and invisible elements (values, assumptions, communication styles, concepts of time and space, approaches to conflict).

The "cultural iceberg" model is a useful metaphor: only a small portion of culture is visible above the surface, while the vast majority — the values, beliefs, and worldviews that drive behaviour — lies beneath.

Multiculturalism

Multiculturalism refers to the coexistence of diverse cultural groups within a society. It recognises and affirms cultural diversity as a social reality. However, multiculturalism does not necessarily imply interaction or exchange between cultures. In a multicultural society, different groups may live side by side without meaningful engagement with one another.

Interculturality

Interculturality goes beyond the mere recognition of diversity. It refers to the dynamic process of interaction, dialogue, and mutual learning between people of different cultural backgrounds. Interculturality is based on the premise that cultures are not self-contained but are constantly evolving through contact and exchange. It emphasises:

- **Dialogue** — active, respectful communication across cultural boundaries
- **Reciprocity** — mutual learning where all parties both give and receive
- **Critical self-reflection** — awareness of one's own cultural conditioning and biases
- **Equity** — recognition of and challenge to power imbalances between cultural groups

Diversity

Diversity refers to the range of human differences, including but not limited to race, ethnicity, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, age, social class, physical ability, religious belief, political conviction, and national origin. In the context of youth work, diversity is both a reality to be acknowledged and a resource to be valued.

Inclusion

Inclusion is the practice of ensuring that all individuals, regardless of their background, identity, or circumstances, have equal access to opportunities and resources and feel a sense of belonging. Inclusion is not merely about physical presence; it is about meaningful participation, voice, and agency.

Social exclusion

Social exclusion refers to the process by which individuals or groups are systematically denied access to rights, opportunities, and resources that are normally available to members of society. Young people with migrant backgrounds, ethnic minorities, those from economically disadvantaged communities, LGBTQ+ youth, and young people with disabilities are particularly vulnerable to social exclusion.

1.3 Why interculturality matters for youth

Young people in Europe today grow up in societies that are more culturally diverse than at any point in history. Migration, globalisation, digital connectivity, and European mobility have transformed the demographic landscape of cities and towns across the continent. For young people, intercultural competence is not an abstract ideal — it is a practical necessity for navigating school, work, and civic life.

Benefits of intercultural competence for young people include:

- **Enhanced empathy and social skills** — the ability to understand and relate to people whose experiences differ from one's own
- **Critical thinking** — the capacity to question assumptions, challenge stereotypes, and evaluate information from multiple perspectives
- **Adaptability** — the flexibility to function effectively in diverse environments
- **Civic engagement** — a deeper understanding of democratic values, human rights, and social justice
- **Personal growth** — increased self-awareness and a more nuanced understanding of one's own cultural identity
- **Employability** — intercultural competence is increasingly valued by employers in a globalised labour market

1.4 Intercultural competence: a framework

Intercultural competence can be understood as a combination of:

- **Attitudes:** Curiosity, openness, respect for cultural diversity, willingness to suspend judgement, tolerance of ambiguity
- **Knowledge:** Understanding of cultural norms, history, and social structures; awareness of how culture influences behaviour and perception
- **Skills:** Active listening, observation, empathy, perspective-taking, critical analysis, conflict resolution, adaptability
- **Action:** The ability to translate attitudes, knowledge, and skills into concrete behaviour — to act as a bridge-builder, mediator, and advocate for inclusion

The development of intercultural competence is not a one-time event but an ongoing process of learning, reflection, and practice.

1.5 The role of youth workers

Youth workers play a critical role in fostering intercultural competence among young people. They create safe spaces for dialogue, facilitate meaningful encounters across cultural boundaries, and model inclusive attitudes and behaviours. Effective intercultural youth work requires:

- **Self-awareness:** Youth workers must first examine their own cultural assumptions, biases, and privileges before facilitating intercultural learning with others.
- **Inclusive facilitation:** Creating an environment where all participants feel valued, heard, and safe to express themselves, including those who may be quieter or less confident.
- **Sensitivity to power dynamics:** Being attentive to the ways in which language, gender, race, socio-economic background, and other factors shape group dynamics.
- **Flexibility and adaptability:** Being prepared to adjust plans, methods, and approaches in response to the needs and dynamics of the group.
- **Ethical responsibility:** Ensuring that intercultural activities do not reinforce stereotypes, exoticise cultural differences, or cause harm.

Chapter 2: Combating racism and discrimination

2.1 Introduction

Intercultural education cannot be separated from the struggle against racism and discrimination. While celebrating cultural diversity is important, it is equally essential to address the structural inequalities, prejudices, and power imbalances that prevent some groups from participating fully

in society. This chapter provides youth workers with the knowledge and tools to recognise, understand, and address racism and discrimination in their work with young people.

2.2 Forms of discrimination

Discrimination takes many forms, some overt and others subtle. Understanding the full spectrum is essential for effective intervention.

Direct discrimination

Direct discrimination occurs when a person is treated less favourably because of a protected characteristic (such as race, ethnicity, religion, gender, sexual orientation, disability, or age). Examples include refusing to hire someone because of their ethnic background, or excluding a young person from an activity because of their religion.

Indirect discrimination

Indirect discrimination occurs when a policy, rule, or practice that appears neutral in fact disadvantages a particular group. For example, a youth centre that only offers activities during hours when young people who observe Friday prayers cannot attend may be indirectly discriminating.

Structural/institutional discrimination

Structural discrimination refers to the ways in which societal institutions — education, employment, housing, healthcare, criminal justice — systematically disadvantage certain groups. It is embedded in policies, practices, and cultural norms, often without deliberate intent.

Intersectionality

Intersectionality, a concept developed by scholar Kimberle Crenshaw, recognises that individuals may experience multiple, overlapping forms of discrimination. A young Black woman, for example, may face discrimination based on both her race and her gender, and these forms of discrimination interact in ways that cannot be understood by examining either one in isolation.

2.3 Stereotypes and prejudice

Stereotypes

Stereotypes are oversimplified, generalised beliefs about a particular group of people. They reduce individuals to a set of assumed characteristics based on their group membership. Stereotypes can be positive (e.g., "Asians are good at maths") or negative (e.g., "Roma people

are criminals"), but all stereotypes are harmful because they deny individuality and reduce complex human beings to caricatures.

How stereotypes work:

- They are learned through socialisation — family, media, education, peer groups
- They are reinforced by selective attention and confirmation bias
- They operate automatically, even among people who consciously reject them
- They have real consequences: they influence hiring decisions, police behaviour, educational expectations, and social interactions

Prejudice

Prejudice is a preconceived opinion or attitude about a group that is not based on reason or actual experience. While stereotypes are cognitive (beliefs), prejudice is affective (feelings and attitudes). Prejudice often leads to discriminatory behaviour.

Microaggressions

Microaggressions are brief, everyday exchanges — verbal, behavioural, or environmental — that communicate hostile, derogatory, or negative messages to members of marginalised groups. They are often unintentional and may seem trivial to the perpetrator, but their cumulative impact is significant. Examples include:

- "Where are you really from?" (denying someone's belonging)
- "You speak [language] so well!" (expressing surprise at competence based on appearance)
- Clutching a bag when a person of colour enters a lift (communicating distrust)
- "I don't see colour" (dismissing someone's lived experience of racism)
- Consistently mispronouncing or shortening someone's name (signalling that their identity is not worth the effort)

2.4 Racism: understanding the concept

Racism is a system of power that combines prejudice with institutional and structural advantage. It operates at multiple levels:

- **Individual racism:** Personal beliefs, attitudes, and actions that perpetuate racial inequality
- **Interpersonal racism:** Discriminatory interactions between individuals
- **Institutional racism:** Policies and practices within organisations that produce racially unequal outcomes
- **Structural racism:** The cumulative effect of historical and contemporary policies, practices, and cultural representations that advantage some racial groups and disadvantage others

It is important to distinguish between racial prejudice (which anyone can hold) and racism as a system of power (which operates along historically established hierarchies).

2.5 Anti-discrimination in youth work: practical approaches

Youth workers can take concrete steps to combat racism and discrimination:

Creating a safe and inclusive space:

- Establish clear group agreements that include respect, confidentiality, and the right to speak and be heard
- Be proactive in addressing discriminatory language or behaviour, even when it appears to be "just a joke"
- Ensure that the physical space, materials, and programme content reflect the diversity of participants

Facilitating critical awareness:

- Use non-formal education methods to help young people recognise stereotypes, prejudice, and discrimination in their own lives and in society
- Encourage young people to share their experiences and perspectives, while being mindful of the emotional weight of such sharing
- Introduce concepts such as privilege, allyship, and systemic inequality in age-appropriate and accessible ways

Modelling inclusive behaviour:

- Be aware of your own biases and how they may affect your facilitation
- Use inclusive language and avoid reinforcing stereotypes
- Actively seek out and amplify the voices of marginalised participants

Taking action:

- Support young people in developing concrete actions to challenge discrimination in their communities
- Connect youth work with broader anti-discrimination and human rights frameworks
- Collaborate with anti-racism organisations and networks

2.6 Legal framework

Youth workers should be aware of the European and national legal frameworks that protect individuals from discrimination:

- **EU Charter of Fundamental Rights** (Article 21: Non-discrimination)

- **EU Racial Equality Directive** (2000/43/EC)
- **EU Employment Equality Directive** (2000/78/EC)
- **European Convention on Human Rights** (Article 14: Prohibition of discrimination)
- **National anti-discrimination legislation** in each EU Member State

Knowledge of these frameworks can help youth workers support young people in understanding their rights and accessing appropriate support when they experience discrimination.

Chapter 3: Non-formal education methods

3.1 What is non-formal education?

Non-formal education (NFE) refers to organised educational activities that take place outside the formal education system. Unlike formal education (which is typically structured, curriculum-based, and leads to recognised qualifications), non-formal education is:

- **Voluntary** — participants choose to take part
- **Learner-centred** — based on the needs, interests, and experiences of the participants
- **Participatory** — learners are active contributors, not passive recipients
- **Process-oriented** — focused on the learning process as much as on outcomes
- **Experiential** — learning by doing, reflecting, and applying

Non-formal education is widely recognised as a powerful approach for youth work and intercultural education. The Council of Europe, the European Commission, and youth organisations across Europe have long advocated for the value and recognition of non-formal learning.

3.2 Why non-formal education works with youth

Non-formal education is particularly effective with young people for several reasons:

- **It respects autonomy:** Young people choose to participate and have agency in shaping their learning experience.
- **It is relevant:** Activities can be designed to address real issues that matter to young people, from identity and belonging to social justice and community development.
- **It is inclusive:** Non-formal education can reach young people who are disengaged from or excluded by the formal education system, including early school leavers, migrants, and young people with fewer opportunities.

- **It develops transversal skills:** Communication, teamwork, critical thinking, creativity, leadership, and intercultural competence — skills that are not always adequately addressed in school curricula.
- **It validates diverse forms of knowledge:** Non-formal education recognises that learning happens everywhere — in communities, in cultural practices, in peer relationships, and in lived experience.

3.3 Key principles of non-formal education

Learning by doing

Participants learn through direct experience — activities, simulations, role-plays, creative projects, community engagement — rather than through lectures or textbooks. Experience is followed by reflection, which deepens understanding and facilitates the transfer of learning to new contexts.

Peer learning

Participants learn from and with each other. In intercultural settings, peer learning is especially powerful: young people from different backgrounds share their knowledge, perspectives, and experiences, creating a rich and diverse learning environment.

Participatory approach

Participants are not passive recipients of knowledge but active co-creators of the learning process. They contribute to setting objectives, designing activities, and evaluating outcomes. This approach builds ownership, motivation, and empowerment.

Holistic learning

Non-formal education engages the whole person — cognitive, emotional, social, and physical dimensions of learning. Activities may involve discussion, movement, creative expression, sensory experience, and emotional reflection.

Safe space

A safe learning environment is one where participants feel comfortable to express themselves, make mistakes, take risks, and engage with challenging topics without fear of judgement or ridicule. Creating a safe space requires clear agreements, sensitive facilitation, and ongoing attention to group dynamics.

Reflection and debriefing

Every activity in non-formal education is followed by a debriefing or reflection session. This is where the deeper learning happens: participants process their experience, share their feelings and thoughts, connect the activity to broader themes, and identify lessons for their lives.

3.4 The experiential learning cycle

The theoretical foundation for much non-formal education is David Kolb's experiential learning cycle, which consists of four stages:

1. **Concrete Experience** — participating in an activity or having an experience
2. **Reflective Observation** — reflecting on the experience (What happened? How did I feel?)
3. **Abstract Conceptualisation** — drawing conclusions and connecting to broader concepts (What does this mean? What can I learn?)
4. **Active Experimentation** — applying the learning to new situations (How can I use this?)

Effective non-formal education activities move through all four stages, ensuring that experience is transformed into meaningful learning.

3.5 The role of the facilitator

In non-formal education, the educator is a **facilitator** rather than a teacher. The facilitator:

- Creates the conditions for learning but does not dictate what is learned
- Asks open-ended questions rather than providing answers
- Manages group dynamics with sensitivity and awareness
- Adapts to the needs and energy of the group
- Is a co-learner, open to being challenged and changed by the process
- Ensures that all voices are heard, including those of quieter or marginalised participants
- Holds the ethical responsibility of the space — intervening when necessary to address harm, exclusion, or conflict

3.6 Designing a non-formal education session

When planning a non-formal education session, consider the following elements:

Element	Key Questions
Objectives	What do I want participants to learn, feel, or be able to do?
Group	Who are the participants? What are their backgrounds, needs, and expectations?
Content	What topic or theme will the session address?
Methods	What activities and techniques will I use?
Materials	What resources, supplies, or spaces do I need?
Time	How much time is available? How will I pace the session?
Debriefing	How will I facilitate reflection and processing?
Evaluation	How will I assess whether the objectives were met?

A well-designed session follows a logical flow: opening (warm-up, introduction), main activity, debriefing/reflection, and closing.

Chapter 4: Workshop toolkit

This chapter provides six ready-to-use workshop activities for intercultural education and social inclusion. Each activity has been developed and tested within the Cultural Bridges project and can be adapted to different contexts, group sizes, and settings.

How to use this toolkit:

- Each activity is self-contained and can be used independently or as part of a longer programme.
- Activities are arranged in a suggested sequence, from introductory/icebreaker to more complex and reflective, but facilitators may reorder them based on their group's needs.
- All activities include tips for adaptation and facilitation.
- Activities are designed for groups of 15–30 participants aged 16–30, but can be adapted for other age groups and group sizes.

Activity 1: Cultural identity map

Type: Icebreaker / Self-reflection

Duration: 45 minutes

Objectives:

- Enable participants to explore and express their own cultural identities
- Recognise the multiplicity and complexity of cultural identity
- Create a foundation of mutual understanding within the group

Materials needed:

- Large sheets of paper (A3 or flipchart) — one per participant
- Coloured markers, crayons, pencils
- Stickers, magazines for cutting out images (optional)
- Glue sticks and scissors (optional)
- Background music (optional, soft and instrumental)

Group size: 10–30 participants

Room setup: Tables arranged for individual work, with space for participants to move around and share

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction (5 minutes)

Welcome participants and explain the activity. Emphasise that there are no right or wrong answers — the map is a personal reflection, and each person decides what and how much to share. Explain that culture is not just about nationality — it includes family, language, food, music, values, hobbies, communities, and much more.

Step 2 — Individual work: Creating the map (15 minutes)

Ask each participant to create a "cultural identity map" on their sheet of paper. They can draw, write, or collage. Suggest the following prompts (display them on a flipchart or slide):

- What languages do you speak? Which one do you dream in?
- What traditions or celebrations are important to you?
- What food reminds you of home?
- What music, art, or stories have shaped you?
- What values did you grow up with?
- What communities or groups do you belong to?
- What makes you feel "at home"?
- What parts of your identity are most visible to others? What parts are hidden?

Encourage participants to be creative and personal. Play soft background music to create a relaxed atmosphere.

Step 3 — Sharing in pairs (10 minutes)

Ask participants to find a partner they do not know well. Each person has 5 minutes to share their map with their partner. The listener should practise active listening — asking questions, showing interest, and avoiding judgement.

Step 4 — Gallery walk (5 minutes)

Invite participants to place their maps on the wall or on tables. Allow time for everyone to walk around and look at each other's maps. Encourage participants to notice similarities and differences.

Step 5 — Debriefing (10 minutes)

Gather the group in a circle for debriefing. Use the following questions:

- How did it feel to create your map? Was anything surprising?
- What did you discover about your partner's cultural identity?
- Did you notice any similarities across the group? Any differences?
- Were there parts of your identity that were difficult to express or that you chose not to share? Why?
- What does this exercise tell us about what "culture" means?

Tips for facilitators

- Some participants may feel that their cultural identity is "boring" or "normal." Reassure them that every person's cultural background is rich and worth exploring.
- Be sensitive to participants who may have complex or painful relationships with their cultural identity (e.g., refugees, adoptees, people who have experienced discrimination).
- If working with a linguistically diverse group, allow participants to use their own language on their maps.
- This activity works well as an opening exercise for a longer programme, as it builds trust and sets a reflective tone.

Activity 2: Stereotype challenge

Type: Awareness-raising / Critical thinking

Duration: 60 minutes

Objectives:

- Help participants identify and critically examine stereotypes
- Understand how stereotypes are formed and reinforced
- Explore the impact of stereotypes on individuals and communities
- Develop strategies for challenging stereotypes in daily life

Materials needed:

- Flipchart paper and markers
- Sticky notes (two colours)
- Printed cards with stereotype statements (prepared in advance by facilitator)
- A "Stereotype Wall" — a large sheet of paper or a section of wall

Group size: 12–30 participants

Room setup: Circle of chairs for discussion, wall space for the Stereotype Wall

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction (5 minutes)

Begin by asking participants: "What is a stereotype?" Collect a few answers and offer a concise definition: "A stereotype is an oversimplified, generalised belief about a group of people that does not account for individual differences."

Explain that in this activity, the group will explore where stereotypes come from, how they affect people, and how to challenge them.

Step 2 — Brainstorming: "What have you heard?" (10 minutes)

Divide participants into small groups (4–5 people). Give each group flipchart paper and markers. Ask them to write down stereotypes they have heard about different groups — national, ethnic, gender, age, religious, or other. Emphasise that they are listing what they have *heard*, not what they *believe*. This distinction is crucial and should be made explicit.

After 7 minutes, ask each group to post their sheet on the Stereotype Wall.

Step 3 — Silent gallery walk (5 minutes)

Invite participants to walk around the Stereotype Wall in silence and read what other groups have written. Give each participant two colours of sticky notes. On one colour, they write a stereotype that has personally affected them. On the other colour, they write a stereotype that surprised them or that they had never thought about before. They stick these notes on the wall.

Step 4 — Large group discussion (15 minutes)

Return to the circle. Facilitate a discussion using the following questions:

- How did it feel to read these stereotypes? Did any of them affect you personally?
- Where do stereotypes come from? (Prompt: media, family, education, history, lack of contact)
- Can stereotypes be positive? Are "positive stereotypes" harmless? Why or why not?
- How do stereotypes affect the people they target? (Prompt: self-fulfilling prophecy, stereotype threat, exclusion, violence)
- Have you ever caught yourself believing or acting on a stereotype? What happened?

Step 5 — Small group work: "Challenging Stereotypes" (15 minutes)

Divide participants into new small groups. Give each group a scenario card with a situation where a stereotype is being expressed (e.g., a joke at a party, a comment by a teacher, a post on social media, a family conversation). Ask each group to discuss:

1. What stereotype is being expressed?
2. Why is it harmful?
3. How could you respond in this situation?

Each group presents their scenario and response to the larger group.

Step 6 — Closing reflection (10 minutes)

Ask each participant to complete one of the following sentences (they can share aloud or write it down):

- "One thing I learned about stereotypes today is..."
- "One thing I will do differently is..."
- "One question I still have is..."

Tips for facilitators

- This activity can bring up strong emotions. Be prepared to hold space for discomfort and to validate participants' feelings.
- Make it absolutely clear from the outset that listing stereotypes is not the same as endorsing them. Establish a non-judgmental atmosphere.
- Be attentive to power dynamics: participants from marginalised groups may find this exercise more emotionally taxing.
- If a participant shares a personal experience of being stereotyped, acknowledge it with empathy and without rushing to "fix" or intellectualise.

- Avoid framing the conversation as "us vs. them" — everyone holds stereotypes, and the goal is awareness and growth, not blame.

Activity 3: Walk in my shoes

Type: Empathy / Role-playing / Simulation

Duration: 90 minutes

Objectives:

- Develop empathy by experiencing a situation from another person's perspective
- Understand the lived experiences of people facing discrimination and exclusion
- Explore the emotional and practical impact of inequality
- Stimulate discussion about power, privilege, and social justice

Materials needed:

- Character cards (prepared in advance — see below)
- A large open space (indoor or outdoor)
- A list of statements (prepared in advance — see below)
- Flipchart and markers for debriefing
- Chairs arranged in a circle for debriefing

Group size: 15–30 participants

Room setup: Large open room or outdoor space with enough room for participants to stand in a line and move forward/backward

Preparation

Character cards: Prepare one card per participant, each describing a fictional person with a specific identity, background, and circumstances. Characters should reflect a diverse range of experiences, including different nationalities, ages, genders, socio-economic backgrounds, ethnicities, sexual orientations, abilities, and migration statuses. Examples:

- "You are a 22-year-old Syrian refugee woman living in a small town in Germany. You have a university degree in engineering but your qualifications are not yet recognised."
- "You are a 19-year-old Polish man from a wealthy family. You are studying business at a prestigious university in Warsaw."
- "You are a 25-year-old Roma man living in a suburb of Paris. You left school at 16 and work in temporary jobs."

- "You are a 17-year-old non-binary person living in rural Spain. Your family does not accept your identity."
- "You are a 28-year-old wheelchair user from the Netherlands. You work as a graphic designer."
- "You are a 20-year-old undocumented migrant from Nigeria living in Italy. You work informally in agriculture."

Statements: Prepare a list of 15–20 statements describing everyday situations. Participants will step forward if their character would be able to do that thing, or stay in place if not. Examples:

- "I can find a job that pays enough to cover my basic needs."
- "I feel safe walking alone at night."
- "I can practise my religion freely without fear."
- "I can easily access healthcare."
- "I can expect the police to treat me fairly."
- "I can marry the person I love legally."
- "I can travel freely within Europe."
- "I can go to university if I want to."
- "I see people who look like me represented positively in the media."
- "I can speak my mother tongue in public without being judged."
- "I have never been called a derogatory name because of my identity."
- "I can find housing without being discriminated against."
- "I feel confident that my voice matters in political decisions."
- "I can get a bank loan if I need one."
- "I can expect my qualifications to be recognised in any EU country."

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction and character distribution (10 minutes)

Explain that in this activity, participants will step into the shoes of someone whose life may be very different from their own. Distribute character cards randomly. Ask participants to read their card silently and to spend a few moments imagining what life is like for their character. Encourage them to think about their character's daily routine, their worries, their hopes, and their challenges. Ask participants not to reveal their character to others.

Step 2 — Guided visualisation (5 minutes)

With participants standing in a line, eyes closed if comfortable, guide them through a short visualisation:

"Imagine you are your character. Think about where you wake up in the morning. What does your room look like? What do you eat for breakfast? Who is around you? How do you feel when you leave the house? What are you looking forward to today? What are you worried about?"

Step 3 — The walk (20 minutes)

Ask participants to stand in a straight line, shoulder to shoulder, facing the same direction. Explain the rules:

- You will read out a series of statements.
- If your character can do or experience what the statement describes, take one step forward.
- If your character cannot, stay where you are.
- If you are not sure, stay where you are.

Read the statements slowly, one at a time, pausing between each to give participants time to decide. After all statements have been read, ask participants to look around and notice where they are in relation to others.

Step 4 — Reveal and initial reactions (10 minutes)

Ask participants to turn around so they can see the whole group. Invite volunteers to share who their character was and how they felt during the exercise. Start with those at the back (who took fewer steps) and then hear from those at the front.

Step 5 — Debriefing in the circle (35 minutes)

Gather the group in a circle. This is the most important part of the activity. Facilitate a deep discussion using the following questions:

Emotional level:

- How did it feel to step forward while others stayed behind?
- How did it feel to stay in place while others moved forward?
- At what point in the exercise did you feel the most emotional?

Analytical level:

- What determined how far forward a character could go? (Prompt: nationality, race, gender, class, ability, legal status)
- Were there characters who were doubly or triply disadvantaged? What does this tell us about intersectionality?
- How realistic were the scenarios? Do you know people in real life who face similar situations?

Action level:

- What can we do, individually and collectively, to create a more equal society?
- What role can youth workers play?
- What did you learn about privilege? About solidarity?

Step 6 — Closing (10 minutes)

Ask each participant to share one word that describes how they feel after the exercise. End with a brief moment of silence or a collective breathing exercise to allow the group to decompress.

Tips for facilitators

- This is an emotionally powerful activity. Ensure that you have sufficient time for debriefing — do not rush it.
- Be prepared for strong emotional reactions, particularly from participants who identify with the characters or who have personal experience of discrimination.
- Emphasise that the characters are fictional, but the situations they face are real.
- Do not assign characters that too closely mirror a participant's actual life situation, as this can be re-traumatising.
- If a participant becomes distressed, offer them the option to step out or to speak privately with a facilitator.
- This activity is adapted from "Take a Step Forward" in the Council of Europe's Compass manual. Credit the original source when using it.

Activity 4: Communication across cultures

Type: Skills development / Interactive exercise

Duration: 60 minutes

Objectives:

- Explore how communication styles vary across cultures
- Identify potential sources of miscommunication in intercultural interactions
- Develop practical skills for effective cross-cultural communication
- Reflect on one's own communication style and assumptions

Materials needed:

- Instruction cards for the simulation (prepared in advance — see below)
- Flipchart paper and markers
- Timer or watch

- Small objects for "trading" (e.g., coloured cards, beads, paper clips)

Group size: 12–30 participants

Room setup: Space for small groups to work separately, then a circle for debriefing

Preparation

Prepare instruction cards for three fictional cultures (adjust the number based on group size). Each culture has distinct communication norms. For example:

Culture A — "The Builders":

- Communication is direct and task-focused
- Eye contact is important and shows respect
- Handshakes are the standard greeting
- Decisions are made quickly by the person with the most experience
- Silence is uncomfortable; fill pauses with talk
- Time is linear; punctuality is highly valued

Culture B — "The Weavers":

- Communication is indirect; it is rude to say "no" directly
- Eye contact with elders or authority figures is considered disrespectful
- Greetings involve placing a hand on your heart
- Decisions are made by group consensus; no one should be left out
- Silence is valued as a sign of thoughtfulness
- Relationships must be built before any business can be discussed

Culture C — "The Nomads":

- Communication is expressive and animated; gestures are essential
- Physical touch (arm, shoulder) during conversation is normal and friendly
- Greetings involve a double cheek kiss
- The youngest person in the group always speaks first
- Interruptions are a sign of engagement, not rudeness
- Time is flexible; starting late is not considered a problem

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction (5 minutes)

Explain that in this activity, participants will experience what it feels like to communicate with people from a very different cultural background. Divide participants into three groups (representing the three cultures) and give each group their culture's instruction card. The groups do not see each other's cards.

Step 2 — Learning the culture (10 minutes)

Each group reads their instruction card and practises their culture's communication norms with each other. They should become comfortable with the greetings, decision-making styles, and communication rules of their assigned culture. Facilitators circulate to answer questions and help groups internalise their norms.

Step 3 — The encounter: Mixed group task (20 minutes)

Create new mixed groups with members from each culture. Give each mixed group a task to complete together — for example:

"You must agree on a plan for a community festival. You need to decide on: a date, a theme, three activities, and how to divide tasks. You have 15 minutes."

Participants must stay in character and follow their culture's communication norms throughout the task. Facilitators observe but do not intervene.

Step 4 — Debriefing (25 minutes)

Return to the large group circle. Facilitate a discussion:

Experience level:

- What happened during your group's discussion? Were you able to complete the task?
- What was challenging about communicating with members of the other cultures?
- Were there misunderstandings? What caused them?
- How did it feel when your communication style was not understood or was perceived negatively?

Analysis level:

- What assumptions did you make about the other cultures? Were those assumptions correct?
- How did differences in communication styles affect decision-making? Power dynamics? Inclusion?
- Can you think of real-life examples where similar miscommunications happen?

Transfer level:

- What strategies can we use to communicate more effectively across cultures?

- What can we do when we encounter a communication style that is very different from our own?
- How can we avoid judging others based on our own cultural norms?

Conclude by summarising key principles of effective intercultural communication:

- **Observe before interpreting** — notice behaviour before assigning meaning
- **Ask, don't assume** — when in doubt, ask respectful questions
- **Adapt, don't abandon** — adjust your style while staying authentic
- **Listen actively** — pay attention to both words and non-verbal cues
- **Embrace discomfort** — miscommunication is a natural part of intercultural interaction

Tips for facilitators

- Make the fictional cultures different enough to generate genuine miscommunication, but avoid cultural caricatures or stereotypes of real cultures.
- If some participants "break character," gently remind them to stay in their assigned culture's norms.
- This activity often generates laughter, frustration, and lively discussion — all of which are valuable learning opportunities.
- In the debriefing, help participants connect the simulation to their real-life experiences of cross-cultural communication.

Activity 5: Co-creating an inclusive community project

Type: Project-based learning / Collaborative planning

Duration: 120 minutes

Objectives:

- Apply intercultural competences to the design of a concrete community project
- Practise collaborative planning, negotiation, and decision-making
- Explore what "inclusion" means in practice
- Develop project management skills (needs analysis, objectives, activities, evaluation)
- Inspire participants to take action in their own communities after the workshop

Materials needed:

- Flipchart paper (multiple sheets per group)
- Markers in various colours
- Sticky notes

- Printed "Project planning template" (one per group — see below)
- Timer
- Materials for presentations (optional: laptop, projector)

Group size: 15–30 participants (working in groups of 4–6)

Room setup: Tables for group work, space for presentations

Project planning template

Each group receives a template with the following sections:

1. **Project Title**
2. **Target Group:** Who is the project for? Who are the people you want to include?
3. **Needs Analysis:** What problem or need does the project address? How do you know this need exists?
4. **Objectives:** What do you want to achieve? (Be specific and realistic)
5. **Activities:** What will you actually do? Describe at least 3 concrete activities.
6. **Inclusion Strategy:** How will you ensure the project is accessible and inclusive for all? Consider language, disability, gender, socio-economic background, cultural diversity.
7. **Timeline:** When will each activity happen?
8. **Resources Needed:** What do you need? (People, materials, budget, space)
9. **Partnerships:** Who could you collaborate with?
10. **Evaluation:** How will you know if the project was successful?

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction and inspiration (15 minutes)

Begin by presenting two or three real examples of inclusive community projects led by young people. These can include:

- A neighbourhood intercultural festival organised by a youth association
- A multilingual storytelling project in a school
- A social media campaign challenging stereotypes
- A community garden that brings together diverse groups
- A peer mentoring programme for newly arrived young migrants

Briefly describe each project and highlight what made it inclusive and impactful. Then explain that participants will now have the opportunity to design their own inclusive community project.

Step 2 — Group formation and brainstorming (15 minutes)

Divide participants into groups of 4–6, ensuring a mix of nationalities, backgrounds, and perspectives in each group. Give each group flipchart paper and sticky notes.

Ask groups to brainstorm project ideas using the following prompt: "If you could create one project to promote inclusion and intercultural understanding in your community, what would it be?"

Each person writes their ideas on sticky notes (one idea per note). Groups then cluster similar ideas, discuss, and select one project to develop.

Step 3 — Project planning (40 minutes)

Distribute the Project planning template. Groups work together to develop their chosen project, filling in all sections of the template. Circulate among groups to offer support, ask probing questions, and ensure that groups are thinking critically about inclusion.

Key questions to prompt deeper thinking:

- "Who might be excluded from this project, even unintentionally? How can you prevent that?"
- "How will you ensure that all voices within the project team are heard?"
- "Is this project realistic? What would you need to make it happen?"
- "How does this project address a real need in the community?"

Step 4 — Preparing presentations (15 minutes)

Each group prepares a 5-minute presentation of their project. Encourage creative presentation formats: a poster, a short skit, a pitch, or a visual map.

Step 5 — Presentations and feedback (25 minutes)

Each group presents their project to the full group. After each presentation, allow 3 minutes for questions and constructive feedback from other participants. Encourage participants to offer specific, actionable feedback.

Step 6 — Debriefing (10 minutes)

Facilitate a closing reflection:

- What did you learn about designing an inclusive project?
- What was the most challenging part of the planning process?
- How did you handle disagreements within your group?
- Could any of these projects actually be implemented? What would be the first step?
- How does this experience connect to the broader themes of our programme?

Tips for facilitators

- Encourage groups to think about inclusion not as an add-on but as a fundamental design principle.
- If groups struggle to choose a topic, offer a menu of themes (e.g., "intercultural cooking," "multilingual art exhibition," "anti-discrimination awareness campaign," "intergenerational storytelling project").
- Emphasise that the goal is not to produce a perfect project plan but to practise the process of collaborative, inclusive planning.
- If time allows, follow up after the workshop to see if any groups have taken steps to implement their projects. This can be a powerful indicator of impact.
- Share the project ideas with the partnership for potential inclusion in dissemination activities.

Activity 6: Message to the future

Type: Creative expression / Closing reflection

Duration: 60 minutes

Objectives:

- Encourage participants to reflect on their learning journey
- Express personal commitments to intercultural understanding and inclusion
- Create a tangible, lasting output that captures the group's collective vision
- Provide emotional closure to the programme

Materials needed:

- Paper in various sizes and colours
- Envelopes
- Markers, pens, coloured pencils
- Art supplies (watercolours, pastels, collage materials) — optional
- A large piece of fabric, paper, or a box to serve as a "time capsule" or collective display
- Background music (reflective and calming)
- Camera/phone for documentation

Group size: 10–30 participants

Room setup: Comfortable space with tables or floor space for creative work; circle of chairs for sharing

Step-by-step instructions

Step 1 — Introduction and reflection (10 minutes)

Invite participants to sit in a circle. Explain that this is the closing activity of the programme and that it is an opportunity to reflect on everything they have experienced, learned, and felt. Ask participants to close their eyes (if comfortable) and think about:

- What was the most meaningful moment of this programme for me?
- What have I learned about myself? About others?
- What do I want to remember?
- What do I want to take with me into the future?

Allow 2–3 minutes of silent reflection.

Step 2 — Writing the message (20 minutes)

Explain that each participant will now write (or create) a "Message to the future." This message can take different forms:

- **A letter to your future self** — what do you want to remember? What commitments are you making?
- **A letter to a young person you have not yet met** — what advice would you give them about living in a diverse world?
- **A poem, drawing, or artistic expression** — capturing the spirit of what you have learned

Provide art supplies and play soft background music. Allow participants to work at their own pace, individually or in a quiet corner. This is a personal, reflective moment — encourage depth over speed.

Step 3 — Sharing (optional) (15 minutes)

Invite participants who wish to share their message to read it aloud or show their creation to the group. Make sharing voluntary — no one should feel pressured. After each sharing, the group can respond with a simple gesture of appreciation (e.g., a round of snapping fingers, placing a hand on their heart, or a collective "thank you").

Step 4 — Creating the collective piece (10 minutes)

Invite each participant to contribute a word, phrase, or image from their message to a collective piece. This could be:

- A large "Quilt of Commitments" — each person writes or draws on a square of fabric or paper, which are then assembled together

- A "Time Capsule" — messages are placed in envelopes and sealed, to be opened at a future date (e.g., one year later)
- A collaborative mural or poster

Take photos of the collective creation for documentation and dissemination.

Step 5 — Closing circle (5 minutes)

Stand in a circle. Each participant says one word that captures their feeling at this moment. The facilitator closes with a brief reflection, thanking participants for their openness and courage, and reminding them that the learning does not end here — it continues in every interaction, every decision, and every act of solidarity in their daily lives.

Tips for facilitators

- This activity is deeply personal. Create a calm, respectful atmosphere. Avoid rushing.
- Some participants may become emotional — this is natural and should be honoured, not suppressed.
- If time allows, consider arranging to send the sealed letters to participants 6–12 months later, as a reminder of their commitments. This can be coordinated with the partner organisations.
- The collective piece can be displayed at local dissemination events or photographed for project reports and publications.
- This activity pairs well with a Youthpass reflection (see Chapter 6), where participants document their key learning competences.

Chapter 5: Organizing an intercultural exchange

5.1 Introduction

This chapter draws on the practical experience of the Cultural Bridges partnership in organising the international youth exchange in Warsaw (14–18 May 2025). It offers guidance for youth workers and organisations planning similar activities.

5.2 Pre-exchange planning

Defining objectives

Before any logistical planning, clarify what you want the exchange to achieve. Objectives should be:

- **Specific** — clearly defined and unambiguous
- **Measurable** — you can assess whether they were met
- **Achievable** — realistic within the available time and budget
- **Relevant** — aligned with the needs of participants and the broader project goals
- **Time-bound** — achievable within the exchange period

For Cultural Bridges, the Warsaw exchange objectives included:

- Facilitate meaningful intercultural dialogue among 30 young people from 3 countries
- Build participants' competences in communication, conflict resolution, and intercultural awareness
- Co-create community project ideas that participants could implement upon return
- Strengthen the partnership between the three organisations

Participant selection and preparation

Selecting the right participants is critical to the success of an exchange:

- **Age and profile:** The exchange targeted young people aged 18–30, with a priority for those with fewer opportunities (economic barriers, geographic isolation, migrant background, first-time participants in mobility programmes).
- **Diversity within national groups:** Ensure that each national group reflects internal diversity — different genders, backgrounds, and experience levels.
- **Preparation:** Organise at least one preparatory meeting with participants before the exchange. Cover: objectives, programme overview, practical information, expectations, fears, and group agreements. Address any anxieties about language, travel, or cultural differences.
- **Inclusion of disadvantaged youth:** Actively reach out to young people who may not typically access international mobility programmes. Provide additional support where needed (travel assistance, pre-departure mentoring, cultural mediation).

Logistics

Key logistical considerations:

- **Venue:** Choose a venue that is accessible, comfortable, and conducive to group work. Consider accessibility for participants with physical disabilities. The Warsaw exchange used a centrally located youth centre with flexible meeting rooms and outdoor space.
- **Accommodation:** Arrange shared accommodation that encourages interaction between national groups while respecting participants' need for privacy and rest.
- **Transport:** Provide clear travel information and support. Consider the environmental impact of travel — favour train over air where possible.

- **Meals:** Accommodate dietary requirements (religious, medical, vegetarian/vegan). Shared meals are important social moments — consider an Intercultural night (see below) where participants share food from their cultures.
- **Insurance:** Ensure all participants are covered by travel and health insurance.
- **Budget:** Plan a realistic budget that covers all costs. Erasmus+ grants for KA210-YOU are lump sums — plan carefully to ensure full coverage.
- **Communication:** Create a shared communication channel (e.g., WhatsApp group, Telegram) for logistical updates and community building before, during, and after the exchange.
- **Visa and travel documents:** For non-EU participants or participants requiring visas, begin the process well in advance.

5.3 Programme design

A well-designed programme balances structured activities with free time, and cognitive learning with emotional and creative experiences.

Principles of good programme design

- **Progressive deepening:** Start with icebreakers and team-building, move to more complex and challenging topics, and close with reflection and forward-looking activities.
- **Variety of methods:** Alternate between discussion, physical activity, creative expression, small group work, and large group sessions.
- **Rhythm and energy management:** Monitor the group's energy levels. Schedule more demanding activities for the morning and lighter activities for the afternoon. Include regular breaks, energisers, and free time.
- **Flexibility:** Be prepared to adapt the programme in response to the group's needs and dynamics. Leave buffer time for unexpected conversations or events.
- **Cultural programme:** Include visits to local cultural sites, engagement with local communities, and opportunities for informal intercultural exchange.

Sample programme: Warsaw exchange (14–18 May 2025)

Time	Day 1 (Wed)	Day 2 (Thu)	Day 3 (Fri)	Day 4 (Sat)	Day 5 (Sun)
Morning	Arrivals and registration	Intercultural workshops	Communication & conflict resolution	Co-creation of community projects	Evaluation and Youthpass
Afternoon	Welcome session, icebreakers, team-building	Creative workshops, presentation by Fundacja Porta	Free time / city exploration	Project presentations	Closing ceremony, departures
Evening	Group dinner	Intercultural night	Free evening	Farewell dinner	—

5.4 Key programme elements

Team-building

Team-building activities at the start of the exchange are essential for creating trust, breaking the ice, and establishing a positive group dynamic. Activities should be physical, fun, and collaborative — not competitive. Examples: human knot, blindfolded trust walk, collective storytelling, group juggle.

Intercultural workshops

The core of the exchange programme. These are facilitated sessions that address the themes of interculturality, inclusion, and anti-discrimination (see Chapter 4 for workshop ideas). Workshops should use non-formal education methods and include time for debriefing.

Intercultural night

A highlight of many international exchanges. Each national group prepares a presentation of their culture — food, music, dance, games, stories, traditions. The Intercultural night is a celebration, not a competition. Guidelines:

- Encourage authentic sharing, not tourist-guide performances
- Ensure that all groups have equal time and resources
- Include interactive elements — teach a dance, share a game, invite others to taste food

- Emphasise that culture is not just about nationality — participants can share elements of their local, regional, or personal culture

Guest speakers and external input

Inviting external speakers or organisations adds depth and credibility. During the Warsaw exchange, **Fundacja Porta** delivered a presentation on their work with migrants and refugees in Poland, providing participants with a concrete example of intercultural solidarity in action.

Creative workshops

Art, music, film, theatre, and creative writing are powerful tools for intercultural education. They allow participants to express themselves in ways that transcend language barriers and engage different intelligences. The Warsaw exchange included creative workshops where participants produced collaborative artworks inspired by their intercultural experiences.

5.5 Group dynamics and facilitation

Working with multilingual groups

In international exchanges, language can be both a barrier and a resource:

- **Working language:** Establish a common working language (usually English), but be aware that not all participants are equally fluent. Speak slowly and clearly, use visual aids, and check understanding regularly.
- **Language support:** Pair stronger and weaker speakers. Use visual materials, demonstrations, and body language to reinforce verbal communication.
- **Multilingualism as a resource:** Encourage participants to teach each other words in their languages. Use multilingual activities (e.g., multilingual welcome posters, collaborative translation exercises).
- **Non-verbal methods:** Many non-formal education activities rely on movement, drawing, and physical expression, making them accessible even to participants with limited language skills.

Managing conflict

Conflict is a natural part of group life, especially in intercultural settings. Effective facilitation involves:

- **Prevention:** Clear group agreements, inclusive facilitation, and regular check-ins reduce the likelihood of conflict.
- **Recognition:** Be attentive to signs of tension — withdrawal, side conversations, body language, shifts in energy.

- **Intervention:** Address conflicts early and directly, using non-violent communication (NVC) techniques. Facilitate dialogue between the parties, focusing on feelings and needs rather than blame.
- **Learning opportunity:** When handled well, conflict is one of the most powerful learning opportunities in an exchange. It can be debriefed and integrated into the programme's themes.

Inclusion of disadvantaged youth

The Erasmus+ programme places a strong emphasis on the inclusion of young people with fewer opportunities. In practice, this means:

- Proactive outreach to communities and organisations that work with disadvantaged youth
- Financial support for travel and incidental costs
- Adapted activities that account for different skill levels, language abilities, and physical needs
- Pairing less experienced participants with mentors or buddies
- Creating a non-judgmental atmosphere where all forms of knowledge and experience are valued
- Flexible programme design that allows for different levels of participation

5.6 Post-exchange follow-up

The exchange does not end when participants go home. Post-exchange follow-up is essential for consolidating learning and ensuring impact:

- **Follow-up meeting:** Organise a meeting with participants 2–4 weeks after the exchange to reflect on the experience and discuss next steps.
- **Community action:** Support participants in implementing the project ideas developed during the exchange in their local communities.
- **Ongoing communication:** Maintain the group communication channel for sharing updates, opportunities, and support.
- **Youthpass:** Issue Youthpass certificates to all participants (see Chapter 6).
- **Dissemination:** Involve participants in sharing the outcomes of the exchange through social media, events, or publications.

Chapter 6: Evaluation and impact measurement

6.1 Why evaluation matters

Evaluation is an integral part of any educational programme. It serves multiple purposes:

- **Accountability:** Demonstrating to funders and stakeholders that objectives were met and resources were well used.
- **Learning:** Understanding what worked, what did not, and why — to improve future practice.
- **Participant development:** Helping participants recognise and articulate their own learning and growth.
- **Visibility:** Generating evidence of impact that can be shared with policymakers, funders, and the wider community.

6.2 Types of evaluation

Formative evaluation (during the programme)

Formative evaluation takes place during the programme and is used to monitor progress and make adjustments. Methods include:

- **Daily reflection circles:** At the end of each day, gather participants to share their highlights, challenges, and feelings. Use prompts like: "One thing I learned today," "One thing that surprised me," "One thing I want to explore further."
- **Mood meters / Emotional thermometers:** Visual tools where participants indicate their emotional state using colours, symbols, or a scale. Useful for monitoring group well-being.
- **Mid-point check-in:** Halfway through the programme, hold a longer feedback session where participants can suggest changes to the programme. Demonstrate that their input is valued by implementing feasible suggestions.
- **Observation:** Facilitators observe group dynamics, participation levels, and behavioural changes throughout the programme.

Summative evaluation (after the programme)

Summative evaluation takes place at the end of the programme and assesses overall outcomes and impact. Methods include:

- **Final evaluation session:** A structured session at the end of the programme where participants reflect on their learning, assess whether objectives were met, and provide feedback on the programme. Can include individual and group components.

- **Questionnaires/Surveys:** Written or online surveys that collect quantitative and qualitative data on participants' experiences, learning, and satisfaction. Include both closed-ended (rating scales) and open-ended questions.
- **Creative evaluation methods:** Drawing, collage, body mapping, or other creative approaches that allow participants to express their learning in non-verbal ways.

Follow-up evaluation (months later)

Follow-up evaluation assesses the longer-term impact of the programme. Methods include:

- **Follow-up survey:** 3–6 months after the programme, contact participants with a short survey asking about lasting impacts, changes in behaviour or attitudes, and actions taken.
- **Interviews or focus groups:** In-depth conversations with a sample of participants about their experience and its aftermath.
- **Tracking community actions:** Monitor whether participants have implemented the project ideas developed during the programme.

6.3 Measuring intercultural learning

Intercultural learning is complex and difficult to measure with simple metrics. Consider assessing changes in the following dimensions:

Dimension	Indicators	Methods
Attitudes	Increased openness, curiosity, and respect towards cultural diversity; decreased prejudice	Self-assessment scales, reflection journals, observation
Knowledge	Understanding of cultural concepts, awareness of discrimination, knowledge of rights	Pre/post quizzes, debriefing discussions, written reflections
Skills	Active listening, perspective-taking, conflict resolution, adaptability	Observation during activities, peer feedback, self-assessment
Behaviour	Seeking intercultural contact, challenging stereotypes, engaging in inclusive practices	Follow-up surveys, interviews, tracking community actions

6.4 Sample evaluation questions

Pre-programme questionnaire (extract)

1. How would you describe your level of experience with intercultural activities? (None / Some / Moderate / Extensive)

2. How comfortable do you feel interacting with people from different cultural backgrounds? (1–5 scale)
3. Can you name three forms of discrimination? (open-ended)
4. What do you hope to learn or gain from this programme? (open-ended)

Post-programme questionnaire (extract)

1. To what extent did the programme meet your expectations? (1–5 scale)
2. What was the most valuable learning experience for you? (open-ended)
3. How has your understanding of interculturality changed as a result of this programme? (open-ended)
4. How comfortable do you now feel interacting with people from different cultural backgrounds? (1–5 scale)
5. Can you describe one concrete action you plan to take to promote inclusion in your community? (open-ended)
6. How would you rate the quality of facilitation? (1–5 scale)
7. What would you change about the programme? (open-ended)
8. Would you recommend this programme to others? (Yes / No / Maybe)

Follow-up survey questions (3–6 months later, extract)

1. Since the programme, have you taken any actions to promote intercultural understanding or inclusion? If yes, please describe.
2. Have you stayed in contact with participants from other countries?
3. Has the experience influenced your educational or career choices?
4. Has your attitude towards cultural diversity changed since the programme? How?
5. Would you be interested in participating in or organising similar activities in the future?

6.5 Youthpass integration

Youthpass is a European recognition tool for non-formal and informal learning in Erasmus+ Youth projects. It is both a certificate and a process.

What is Youthpass?

Youthpass certificates confirm participation in an Erasmus+ Youth project and describe the learning outcomes achieved by the participant. They are linked to the **Key Competences for Lifelong Learning**, as defined by the European Parliament and Council:

1. Literacy competence
2. Multilingual competence

3. Mathematical competence and competence in science, technology, and engineering
4. Digital competence
5. Personal, social, and learning to learn competence
6. Civic competence
7. Entrepreneurship competence
8. Cultural awareness and expression competence

Using Youthpass as a learning tool

Youthpass is not just a certificate to be handed out at the end of a project — it is a tool for deepening reflection and self-awareness:

- **Integrate Youthpass reflection throughout the programme:** At regular intervals, ask participants to reflect on which competences they are developing and how.
- **Use the Key Competences as a framework:** During debriefing sessions, help participants connect their experiences to the competence framework.
- **Individual reflection time:** Set aside dedicated time for participants to write their Youthpass learning descriptions. Provide support for those who need help articulating their learning.
- **Celebrate the certificate:** Present Youthpass certificates in a meaningful closing ceremony, not as an afterthought.

Youthpass and Cultural Bridges

In the Cultural Bridges project, the following competences are particularly relevant:

- **Personal, social, and learning to learn competence:** Self-reflection, empathy, teamwork, communication, conflict resolution
- **Civic competence:** Understanding of human rights, anti-discrimination, active citizenship, democratic participation
- **Cultural awareness and expression competence:** Appreciation of cultural diversity, creative expression, intercultural dialogue
- **Multilingual competence:** Communication in diverse linguistic environments, appreciation of multilingualism

6.6 Reporting to the national agency

For Erasmus+ KA210-YOU projects, the coordinating organisation (Associacio Juvenil Ndiatiguia Joves Units) is responsible for submitting a final report to the Spanish National Agency. The report should include:

- A description of activities carried out

- Evidence of participation (participant lists, photos, Youthpass certificates)
- Evaluation data (survey results, testimonials, impact indicators)
- Intellectual outputs produced (including this guide)
- Dissemination activities and their reach
- Financial reporting (in accordance with the lump sum grant)
- Reflection on challenges, lessons learned, and sustainability

Evaluation data collected throughout the project directly feeds into this report. Good evaluation practice throughout the project makes final reporting easier and more compelling.

Resources and references

European resources

- **SALTO-YOUTH Resource Centres:** www.salto-youth.net — Training, tools, and resources for youth workers working in the Erasmus+ programme. The SALTO Cultural Diversity Resource Centre and SALTO Inclusion & Diversity Resource Centre are particularly relevant.
- **Council of Europe — Youth Department:**
- **Compass: Manual for Human Rights Education with Young People** — www.coe.int/compass — A comprehensive manual of activities for human rights education. Activities like "Take a Step Forward" (adapted in this guide as "Walk in My Shoes") are widely used in intercultural education.
- **T-Kit Series:** A series of training kits for youth workers:
- T-Kit 4: Intercultural Learning — pjp-eu.coe.int/en/web/youth-partnership/t-kit-4-intercultural-learning
- T-Kit 8: Social Inclusion — pjp-eu.coe.int/en/web/youth-partnership/t-kit-8-social-inclusion
- T-Kit 11: Mosaic: The Training Kit for Euro-Mediterranean Youth Work
- **European Portfolio for Youth Leaders and Youth Workers** — A self-assessment tool for youth workers to evaluate and develop their competences.
- **Youthpass:** www.youthpass.eu — The official Youthpass portal for creating and managing Youthpass certificates.
- **European Commission — Erasmus+ Programme Guide:** erasmus-plus.ec.europa.eu — Official programme guide with information on KA2 partnerships, eligibility, and reporting.
- **European Youth Portal:** youth.europa.eu — Information on opportunities, rights, and resources for young people in Europe.

Key publications

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- Rosenberg, M. B. (2003). *Nonviolent Communication: A Language of Life.* PuddleDancer Press.
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Online tools and platforms

- **Padlet** (padlet.com) — Digital collaboration boards for brainstorming, sharing, and documentation
- **Mentimeter** (mentimeter.com) — Interactive presentations with live polling, quizzes, and word clouds
- **Kahoot** (kahoot.com) — Game-based learning platform for quizzes and surveys
- **Canva** (canva.com) — Design tool for creating visual materials, posters, and presentations
- **Google Forms** (forms.google.com) — Free survey tool for evaluation questionnaires

Networks and organisations

- **UNITED for Intercultural Action** — European network against nationalism, racism, fascism, and in support of migrants and refugees. www.unitedagainstracism.org
- **European Youth Forum** — Platform of national youth councils and international youth organisations. www.youthforum.org
- **ENAR (European Network Against Racism)** — www.enar-eu.org

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Partner organisations

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- **Associacio Juvenil Ndiatiguia Joves Units** (Barcelona, Spain) — Coordinating Organisation
- **UGPA POLSKA** (Warsaw, Poland)
- **Un Geste pour l'Avenir** (France)

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Contributors and partners

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For more information about the Erasmus+ programme, visit: erasmus-plus.ec.europa.eu

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